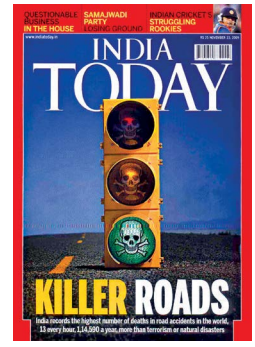
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Our brand-new highways are a matter of pride as they cover an increasing part of our landscape. A key component of our development agenda, their expansion is crucial to maintaining or even increasing our GDP growth rate. However, it has been accompanied by a negative side-effect that's rising alarmingly—highway accidents, often involving a pile-up with multiple high-speed vehicles and high fatalities. This is a sign of our overall regulatory systems not keeping pace with development. Annually, accident fatalities on Indian highways now range over 100,000. That means 274 people dying daily or 11 every hour. Despite the fact that national highways account for barely 2.1 per cent of the 6.3 million km of roads across India, they share a vastly disproportionate 36 per cent of the overall fatality burden. The number is not random: national highways account for a third of the average 443,000 grievous injuries in road accidents. If you include state highways, the equation becomes starker: 60 per cent of the deaths occur on just five per cent of the total road length.



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We tend to think of accidents as random occurrences, and the pattern tends to elude us. However, the overall fatality rates are beginning to be comparable to that of the pandemic. It's time India began to look seriously at the causes and solutions. Fortunately, we have someone in charge who is not only a doer but is also acutely alive to the situation. Nitin Gadkari, the Union minister of road transport and highways, had himself been in a highway accident in 2004, and suffered multiple bone fractures. So, he's able to see things from the victim's perspective. When he took charge in 2014, one of the first things he did was to make road safety audits mandatory on all national and state highways. He asked the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) to identify accident blackspots. The results were an eye-opener. By 2021, the NHAI had identified 5,352 blackspots based on accident and fatality data for 2016-2018. Since then, 4,005 blackspots have been permanently rectified. So far, Rs 15,700 crore has been spent on eliminating the engineering defects.

Research has identified five factors that cause deaths on the highways: rank bad traffic discipline; poor and thoughtless road engineering; lax enforcement; poor vehicle design; and a woeful lack of speedy access to treatment. The number of glaring engineering defects on major highways has startled researchers. In their safety audit of the old Mumbai-Pune highway, the NGO SaveLIFE Foundation found 37 blocks that obscured driver vision, 21 roadside trees, 67 kerb stones, 162 sharp curves, 275 concrete structures on the road and 218 km of narrow stretches. This is not counting stray cattle, of course. Not to mention that other victim, the pedestrian, who is as much of a participant in road discipline and has mostly been an afterthought in India's road design. A lot of focus recently, therefore, has been on building safe pedestrian passages like underpasses and overbridges.

Overspeeding alone claims over 75 per cent of lives in highway crashes. But speed doesn't produce crashes on its own. It's when that is juxtaposed with other uniquely Indian behavioural traits that we have a problem. Take driving on the wrong side of the road, zero lane sense and other anarchic traffic violations of this ilk. Lax rules and enforcement, an old bane in India, are beginning to see some movement. Since 2019, the Motor Vehicles Act has been frequently amended to tighten the norms: the penalty for drunken driving, for instance, has increased from Rs 2,000 to Rs 10,000 and a suspension of licence. The only way is to emulate countries with the safest highways, like the Netherlands, Norway and Singapore. There's no instrument better for bringing about a change in behavioural psychology than a stiff fine. We can do with a well-staffed, upright traffic police to complete the circle. Alongside, new safety-related grade certifications for vehicles are beginning to produce results: more of them are now willing to instal airbags for all passengers.

Post-accident access to emergency trauma care naturally has a huge impact on fatality rates. Getting victims medical attention within the 'golden hour' is key. But this brings in other elements like the even spread of medical facilities so that no place on highways is too far from a well-equipped trauma centre. Getting this network in place has been a complicated affair because health is on the concurrent list, and this brings in state governments. On top of that, we neither have an adequate number of ambulances, nor a uniform ambulance number across India. The increasing privatisation of tolled highway stretches increases the degree of coordination required. Bystander apathy is another issue: our laws have only recently been turned around to protect good samaritans.

The first priority is, of course, to cut down on accident occurrence itself. "The problem is very, very serious," Gadkari tells INDIA TODAY in an exclusive interview. "Even when fighting extremist organisations or in a war, the death toll is much lower. Road accident deaths are among the top killers in the country." In terms of human capital, they are estimated to cost 3.14 per cent of India's GDP a year. This week, we turn our attention to a topic that's often buried as a routine matter. But safety cannot be put off for another day. After all, it is a matter of life and death.

(Aroon Purie)